

Chapter 25-1

Cheng Ran saw Liang Shi's text message when she was completely drunk.

She was sprawled out on the sofa, her long hair scattered on the floor, merely glancing at her phone with indifference.

She snorted softly, "Trash."

Then she blocked her number.

And hummed a song softly.

Cheng Ran had many friends, she wasn't lacking this one.

But she and Liang Shi got along the best, having known each other since they were very young, fooling around together during school.

In the end, she was being cut off.

Although Cheng Ran found out it was because she had amnesia.

So what if she had amnesia? Did that mean she could disown her friends?

Especially with how decisive her words were that day.

Cheng Ran just wanted to teach her a lesson.

Didn't she like her Omega? Then she would destroy her Omega.

But at the crucial moment, she still went soft.

A friend's wife should not be touched¹.

Cheng Ran didn't touch Xu Qingzhu, though to be fair, Xu Qingzhu was indeed alluring.

What Cheng Ran was troubled about now was getting involved with Zhou Yi'an.

And that woman was a pervert.

She could guess what Liang Shi wanted to do by coming to see her now - nothing more than beating her up and questioning why she would target an Omega.

There weren't so many whys in this world.

She did it because she wanted to.

Cheng Ran wasn't in the mood to argue and confront her now, or even fight.

She simply couldn't be bothered.

After blocking Liang Shi's number, Cheng Ran called her assistant again, asking her to book a flight abroad.

As the noise of this city gradually fell behind the curtains, Cheng Ran also fell asleep in the loneliness.

Footnotes:

¹ "A friend's wife should not be touched" (朋友妻，不可欺) - A Chinese idiom meaning one should not pursue or harm a friend's spouse/partner out of respect and loyalty.

Chapter 25-2

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On the other side of this city, Liang Shi sat in the living room turning her phone around.

The living room had only one night light on, making the vast space appear empty.

But it was conducive to thinking.

She sent a text to Cheng Ran but got no reply, and when she called, it went straight to busy signal.

She could guess the answer.

She didn't even need to ask for the reason.

For people like Cheng Ran and her group, as long as the mood struck them, they would even play themselves to death, let alone others.

Just like the incidents that Huayue International covered up every year - countless.

Although Zhao Xuning could threaten a powerless manager, saying she could use media power to expose Huayue International's affairs, which would cause Huayue International's reputation to plummet overnight and potentially evaporate billions in stock market value.

But the cost of doing so would be enormous.

The power of capital was sometimes unshakeable precisely because pulling one thread would affect the whole body¹.

Liang Shi looking for Cheng Ran was just to say that if there were any problems in the future, she could come directly to her.

She would accompany her to the end, rather than going after Xu Qingzhu.

Taking over the original owner's body also meant taking over her mess.

Even the chain reactions caused by her own OOC² behavior, she would bear the consequences together.

Liang Shi had been mentally prepared for this.

The most troublesome thing was that she was isolated and helpless here.

Like what happened tonight, she was too passive and couldn't do anything.

Standing in the corridor of Huayue International, she suddenly realized that in such an environment, she couldn't protect the people she wanted to protect.

This was her first time stepping into high society, and only then did she realize that even wealthy families had hierarchies.

In the face of sufficiently powerful authority, money was just so-so.

This was a world completely different from her previous living environment.

She was about to witness a reality more cruel than the entertainment industry.

She had always disliked involving other people.

This would make her feel guilty and remorseful.

Perhaps it was related to her childhood experiences - she had never truly protected someone with all her heart.

For her, being able to protect herself was already difficult enough.

In the dog-eat-dog entertainment industry, she was able to climb up from the bottom and be nominated for Best Actress.

This was not unrelated to her ability to take care of herself.

It wasn't that she lacked compassion or sympathy, but under circumstances where she could barely protect herself, those were all meaningless.

She had always had boundaries.

But with Xu Qingzhu, she was slightly losing her boundaries.

This might also be related to her just arriving here and not yet being familiar with the environment.

Footnotes:

¹ "Pulling one thread affects the whole body" (牵一发而动全身) - A Chinese idiom meaning that a small change can affect the entire situation.

² OOC - "Out of Character" - refers to acting differently from one's usual personality or expected behavior.

Chapter 25-3

Liang Shi curled up on the sofa and thought for a long time, then went to the kitchen to pour herself a glass of water.

Xu Qingzhu was sleeping soundly, and she didn't want to go up and squeeze in. She simply sat on the sofa in a daze, waiting until she felt sleepy before going upstairs.

Where to sleep at night was still a problem.

The carpet was newly changed, but she hadn't found any blankets yet.

Sharing a bed with Xu Qingzhu was obviously impossible.

So after thinking it over, the best place to rest was actually the living room sofa.

Just as she was mentally sorting through the events of these past few days, the very light sound of a door being pushed open rang out.

She looked up and saw Xu Qingya coming out of her room.

Wearing headphones, holding her phone horizontally while playing a game, probably afraid of disturbing them, she kept her voice low while coordinating with others: "Go left, left side, you idiot, can't even tell left from right."

She spoke while walking toward the kitchen, but because she wasn't watching where she was going, she accidentally tripped on the step. Her pupils immediately contracted, but she still suppressed herself from crying out. Fortunately, she didn't fall, just stumbled awkwardly, her instep getting knocked and making her grimace in pain.

However, she finally looked up and saw Liang Shi.

Liang Shi nodded at her.

Xu Qingya took off her headphones, "Sister Liang, you're not sleeping yet?"

"I'll sleep in a bit." Liang Shi drained the water in her glass and reminded her: "You should sleep early too."

Xu Qingya looked confused: "Oh."

She walked toward the kitchen, but after a few steps turned back, took off her headphones, and said seriously and solemnly: "Sister Liang, I have a question."

"What?" Liang Shi asked in a low voice.

"You married my sister, right?" Xu Qingya said.

Liang Shi nodded.

"Tonight my sister was drugged with that kind of drug. Obviously, as long as you two just... did that once, the drug's effect on her would have been resolved." Xu Qingya spoke euphemistically, but everyone could understand. Sometimes Liang Shi would marvel at the magic of language.

Using pronouns to replace words that were embarrassing to say out loud, both parties could understand the meaning.

"But you had me find a family doctor instead." Xu Qingya said: "Between you two, who has the problem?"

She stared straight at Liang Shi, as if trying to bore a hole through her.

"Logically speaking, I shouldn't be asking about these things." Xu Qingya shrugged, "You know, I'm just a minor."

Liang Shi: "..."

You still remember you're a minor?

If she hadn't said so, Liang Shi would have almost forgotten.

Xu Qingya was frighteningly precocious.

"Hey, Sister Liang, don't look at me like that." Xu Qingya said: "I've never been in a relationship, I just heard what others said. The thing about Xu Qingzhu is, her personality is too stubborn. When she likes something, she never takes the initiative to ask for it. If you give it to her, she'll take it, but if you don't give it, no matter how much she likes it, she won't open her mouth to ask for it. Also, she's never been in a relationship. In our family all these years, we've all accommodated her. So I'm wondering, is it because after you got to know her, you understood her personality, so you two don't get along?"

Liang Shi immediately shook her head, "That's not the case."

"You don't need to hide it from me." Xu Qingya said: "Actually, I don't like Xu Qingzhu either. If you don't like her, just tell me, we can badmouth her together."

Liang Shi: "...?"

She suspected Xu Qingya was fishing for information.

Liang Shi said helplessly: "I don't dislike your sister. Taking advantage of someone when they're not clear-headed isn't good."

Xu Qingya: "But you're married, it's legal."

"Your sister would be uncomfortable." Liang Shi said: "She was both drinking and drugged with an aphrodisiac. Having the family doctor help her reduce the fever and get a good night's sleep was the best choice."

Xu Qingya was still somewhat suspicious, her tone reluctant: "Fine."

"Alright, you little devil." Liang Shi smiled: "Your sister and I are doing well. Your sister's personality isn't as stubborn as you say, she's quite cute. Don't always badmouth her. If I hear you doing it again, I'll tell on you."

Xu Qingya rolled her eyes, "Go ahead and tell, I'm not afraid of her."

But she still hesitated, "You two really have no problems?"

"No problems." Liang Shi's smile was warm, even her eyes carried a few traces of indulgence, "Being able to marry your sister, I'm blessed for three lifetimes."

Xu Qingya shivered, "That's so cheesy it's killing me."

She pouted and walked toward the kitchen, waving her hand as she went, "Sister Liang, sleep early. I'm going to drink some water and then sleep too."

"Drink less." Liang Shi advised, "Drinking too much water before bed makes you puffy easily."

"Got it." Xu Qingya put her headphones back on.

Liang Shi watched her retreating figure, feeling that this little girl wasn't as bad as she had seemed when they first met.

She just had a bit of teenage rebellion.

Sharp-tongued and proud.

A stark contrast to Xu Qingzhu's personality.

Liang Shi watched for a while then turned to go upstairs, but just as she climbed two steps, she heard Xu Qingya's voice ring out in the living room.

"I'm not going back yet, I'll talk about it after school starts."

"Why am I staying? Do you even need to ask? To supervise!"

"I suspect my sister and her wife have a marriage of convenience¹. It's so late and my sister's wife still hasn't returned to the room."

Liang Shi's foot slipped and she almost fell.

She didn't believe that Xu Qingya didn't know she was here!

She clearly knew, but deliberately said this just to let her hear.

Liang Shi: "..."

"I need to observe for a while." Xu Qingya continued: "Anyway, our family is a complete mess right now. I need to make sure someone in the family can live well. Xu Qingzhu has princess syndrome, I need to see if she has a princess's fate."

"Probably not. I still think they're in a marriage of convenience."

Liang Shi: "...?"

Was it that obvious?

Liang Shi climbed the stairs with heavy steps back to the room.

When the room door closed, Xu Qingya took off her headphones, looked back at the second floor, and sent her mother a text: [They went into the same room to sleep.]

Footnotes:

¹ Marriage of convenience (形婚) - A marriage entered into for practical reasons rather than love, often to hide one's true sexual orientation or for other benefits.

Chapter 25-4

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The room was even darker than the living room, with only a small bedside night light on.

Still near the balcony area.

When she first entered, Liang Shi hadn't yet adjusted to the dimness inside the room and almost bumped her head against the wall.

Clearly, she wasn't the one who had been drinking, yet she felt somewhat dizzy and disoriented.

Xu Qingzhu was sleeping soundly, or rather, in a deep slumber.

The room was filled with the sound of steady breathing.

When she was asleep, she was extremely well-behaved, showing no trace of the evening's commotion.

Liang Shi sat by the bed for a while, then curled up in the corner sofa.

Being tall with long legs, curling up on the sofa was too cramped. She looked toward Xu Qingzhu in the dim light.

She really wanted to ask the system: Hey? Are you there? Arrange a bed for me.

Unfortunately, there was no response.

The system wouldn't bother with such trivial matters.

But for Liang Shi, this was a big deal.

She had always had requirements for sleep. Even when filming night scenes, she would definitely find time to sleep on a comfortable bed.

If there was no bed, she'd rather not sleep at all.

She couldn't sleep on the sofa, so she simply got up again. After going back and forth several times, she felt somewhat irritated.

After a moment, she turned on the dim yellow bedside lamp.

She pulled out a book from the bedside drawer - it was a poetry collection.

From the wear marks, it looked like it belonged to Xu Qingzhu.

The poetry collection was entirely in English. Liang Shi couldn't read much of it. Her English level was limited to oral communication, and even then, only simple conversations.

This was something her agent had arranged with foresight, thinking that she might go international someday. To prevent her from being mocked for lacking culture when accepting awards abroad, she had specifically hired a teacher to practice spoken English with her.

Liang Shi casually flipped through a few pages and put it back.

There wasn't much in the room for her to pass the time with, so she could only take out her phone, open a video app, and randomly clicked on a movie to watch.

She leaned against the headboard. The soft cushions were quite comfortable, relieving the fatigue from her busy day.

She piled all of the large double quilt on Xu Qingzhu's side. The bundled-up quilt clearly divided this bed with a boundary like the Chu River and Han Border¹. One side had someone sleeping soundly, the other side didn't even have room to turn over.

But having a place where Liang Shi could be slightly more comfortable meant she wouldn't be so irritated.

The movie was an old film. Liang Shi discovered that some of her favorite movies from her world also existed here, along with some new films she'd never heard of. The production of new films inevitably involved new stars, and Liang Shi didn't recognize any of these stars.

She clearly realized that this wasn't the entertainment industry of her world.

But being able to start over in a new place was still quite exciting.

Although she hadn't yet gotten her own body back, Liang Shi was already looking forward to entering the industry and acting.

After all, having lived for so many years, acting was what gave her the most sense of achievement and allowed her to realize her self-worth.

Thinking of this, she couldn't help but look toward Xu Qingzhu.

She thought to herself: How can I win you over?

The system's exact words were: gain her favor, trust, and adoration.

It was really a highly technical job.

Being able to achieve the first two points would already be difficult.

But still, as she'd said before, take it one step at a time.

Liang Shi never wasted today's time worrying excessively about tomorrow's affairs.

The movie was a same-sex film, set in the background before ABO gender differentiation.

The opening frame was white text on a black background - "Once, society wouldn't allow us to love."

The second line - "But we insisted on embracing tightly in crowds, kissing passionately."

Just these two lines stirred Liang Shi's emotions, and she lowered her eyelashes to watch quietly.

This movie told the story of two girls falling in love in college. One was a dance major, specializing in ballet, a typical campus goddess, bright and dazzling, the object of many male students' admiration. She participated in various competitions, winning awards left and right. Being the school beauty was her label.

The other female lead appeared plain and ordinary in comparison. She was timid and had low self-esteem. Although pretty, she didn't show her brilliance much, and because she didn't know how to dress up, she appeared rustic. On the first day of school, these two became roommates in the same dormitory.

The insecure one clumsily imitated the radiant one.

Wanting to become a second version of her, wanting to become popular like her.

But she was always on the periphery of groups. When the dormitory had gatherings, they left her behind. When everyone went traveling, they left her behind too.

They chatted about clothes, bags, and cosmetics, and she could only be a quiet observer.

Whenever she gathered courage to join the conversation, she would become a conversation killer. The previously cheerful atmosphere would suddenly cool down.

Gradually, she no longer inserted herself into these topics, becoming solitary.

And the one isolated along with her was the excellent radiant one.

Because she was too outstanding, she was seen as someone who loved showing off, incompatible with ordinary people, and would also become the target of everyone's dislike.

Their connection began with a song, because they both loved that song, so they had dinner together.

Gradually, their understanding of each other deepened. One was a dancer, the other could play elegant piano.

They developed a unique understanding between them. Going out, holding hands, linking arms, acting cute with each other. When they needed to do something, just one look from each other and they would understand.

The goddess rejected all her suitors, remaining single all along.

So there were rumors saying they were a couple, that the goddess didn't date because she had issues with her sexual orientation.

The rumors grew more intense. The insecure one took the initiative to distance herself, suppressing her inner feelings while feeling dejected during the day and unable to sleep at night, yet she couldn't help but care about her movements - who she had dinner with, how many classes she attended, what people she met.

This stiff relationship lasted for several months.

Until one day, on a bus, the goddess encountered sexual harassment. For the first time, the insecure one stood up so bravely. She stood on the moral high ground and severely condemned that person, and pulled her hand.

In that instant, their fingers interlocked.

That was the bravest moment of her life.

After getting off the bus, by the azure seaside, the insecure one gathered courage to ask, "May I kiss you?"

The movie reached its climax here. This was a restrained yet intimate kiss.

This movie's color palette was very comfortable. The kiss scene placed against such a background had a tragic feeling. The two female leads had different styles - one was the intense beauty type, the other was the pure type.

The pure one was tainted with unknown desires, kissing passionately and desperately.

While the seemingly intense one could only respond clumsily.

This kiss scene lasted two minutes, and the comments were going crazy.

Liang Shi found them distracting and turned off all the comments.

To say something mood-killing, she wasn't immersed in the emotions of the two protagonists, but was watching the camera work.

After all, as an actress, she knew how such kiss scenes were filmed.

Footnotes:

¹ Chu River and Han Border (楚河漢界) - Refers to the boundary lines on a Chinese chess board, metaphorically meaning a clear division or boundary between two sides.

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Around them were set up more than a dozen machines, with dozens of staff members on scene. When filming close-ups, the actors themselves kissed toward the camera, so this kind of scene didn't create too strong a stimulus for her.

The film's pace quickened at this moment. After the kiss came the bedroom scene with the lights dimmed.

This director's control over this type of shot was too strong, making Liang Shi once suspect that this person had started out making adult films. Before this bedroom scene, she specifically searched for information and found that wasn't the case.

This person started out making serious documentaries, specifically about cultural relics and such. Halfway through, they suddenly switched and decided to make movies. This was their first film after changing tracks.

It had to be said, this director had something special about them.

They filmed a bedroom scene that was both pure and sensual.

Close-ups of fingers unbuttoning clothes, hearts beating rapidly and intensely from nervousness, breathing that couldn't be calmed - all focused on the second and third buttons of the shirt.

The female lead's fingers were slender, but appeared clumsy when unbuttoning, drawing out the audience's anticipation.

The other female lead, because her movements were too slow and she couldn't wait, reached over to help her.

The moment their fingers touched, it triggered a new round of kissing.

Then came close-ups of the lighting, pulling from near to far, but the sound from the speakers didn't diminish.

Such sounds were usually dubbed by professional voice actors, with high compatibility to the actors' own voices.

At such moments, having no visuals was better than having visuals.

After cutting the scene came character close-ups - one quilt wrapped around two people, a very passionate bed scene.

Just as Liang Shi was hesitating whether to skip this scene, her finger not yet touching the screen, a weak voice came from beside her: "Water..."

Xu Qingzhu was half-awake, her throat so dry and hoarse she could barely speak. Even using all her strength to say one word felt like her throat had been scraped with sand, painfully so.

She frowned, her body's discomfort not yet completely relieved.

Hearing this, Liang Shi immediately put down her phone and got up to get her a water cup.

Then she walked to her side, supporting her back to help her drink.

She was like a traveler walking in the desert, extremely parched. Her hot palm lightly brushed across Liang Shi's hand holding the water cup.

She gulped down an entire cup, with water stains still remaining at the corners of her mouth.

Those lips, moistened by water, glistened like ripples.

It easily brought to mind the surface of the sea with ripples, as if thousands of acres of sunset were scattered upon it, lustrous and radiant.

Even half-awake, she politely said thank you.

Liang Shi originally thought she would wipe away the water stains at the corners of her mouth before sleeping again, but clearly, she had no such awareness at the moment. After drinking the water, she lay back down on the bed, but her palm still rested on the back of Liang Shi's hand, pulling her down with the momentum.

Liang Shi's heart seemed to have fallen somewhere unknown, her thoughts somewhat drifting, and she was effortlessly pulled down by her.

When Liang Shi realized what was happening, her ear was only millimeters away from Xu Qingzhu, as if those lips glistening with water stains would touch her ear in the next second.

Her ear could feel the warm moisture, like sea breeze gently caressing.

The warm yellow light stretched this enchantment to its extreme.

Like a trap made of light - one careless step and you would fall in.

And when falling into the light, you would quickly be enveloped by tender desire.

But Liang Shi quickly sat up straight. She took a deep breath.

She freed her hand from Xu Qingzhu's grasp and fanned her burning cheeks with her hand.

She had been so content with solitude for so many years, how had she become so flustered by temptation just a few days after coming here?

Like desire that had been dormant for a long time feeling the spring air and eagerly wanting to break through the soil.

Yet she forcibly suppressed it.

Liang Shi placed the water cup to one side and glanced at Xu Qingzhu, who had fallen asleep again.

The water stains at the corners of her mouth still glistened. Having OCD about such things, Liang Shi raised her hand to wipe them away.

Her thumb touched those bright red lips, and the sensation of skin against skin became real in an instant. Even though she tried her best to suppress her desires, physiological things were hard to forcefully suppress. Liang Shi turned to look at her sideways.

After a long while, she turned her face away and covered it with her hands.

Her ears were already starting to burn.

Liang Shi got up and went to the bathroom to take a shower.

It was... quite hard to endure.

After showering, she came out with coolness all over her body. After dismissing all those random thoughts from her mind, she became somewhat more clear-headed.

She returned to the bedside again, deliberately pushing that bundle of quilt toward Xu Qingzhu's side. She occupied a small space and continued watching the movie.

On her phone screen were two bodies entwined. In this book's world, film and television requirements regarding sexual content weren't censored too severely. As it turned out, audiences loved watching it too, especially well-made ones that would have extremely high box office returns.

So this movie had quite a few sexual scenes.

The segment she had seen before used empty shots¹ - that is, when it was time to dim the lights, they directly switched to night scenes of the city.

This was also a common technique directors used when filming such scenes.

But this time it wasn't like that. Instead, they explicitly filmed this scene.

They were in a dim room, on one bed, with fingers falling on each other's softness.

They gazed at each other, looking deeply into each other's eyes...

"So hot..." came Xu Qingzhu's somewhat suppressed voice.

Even more enchanting than the voices of the characters in the movie at their most passionate moments.

Liang Shi immediately pulled the quilt toward herself a bit, and Xu Qingzhu half-opened her eyes, just in time to see the scene on the screen.

That was probably the most passionate segment of the movie.

The two female leads became one in that moment, reaching directly into each other's souls.

The sound of water arose everywhere.

The entire room echoed with the voices of the two, gently calling each other's names.

The names were spoken against the tip of the tongue, and they were close enough that they only needed to use whispered breath to hear clearly.

Liang Shi: "..."

She immediately turned her phone face down.

But the sound continued, accompanied by the enchanting background music.

Anyone would think impure thoughts.

"I didn't..." Liang Shi instinctively wanted to explain, but Xu Qingzhu smiled instead. Her voice, not yet fully awake, was even more alluring than what was in the movie as she asked: "Was it good?"

Liang Shi: "...Not bad."

She had never been good at lying.

And her brain had a momentary short-circuit, so she just went along with her words.

She heard Xu Qingzhu say: "Finish watching and sleep early."

Liang Shi: "...?"

That's it?

Liang Shi thought she had woken up and wanted to ask where the blankets were, but before she could speak, she saw her turn over and start breathing evenly again.

"?"

What a false alarm.

But this was also quite embarrassing for Liang Shi.

Her previous image had always been that of a serious veteran cadre with a Buddhist² demeanor. Watching adult films didn't quite fit her image.

Although she had... watched them before.

This was a very normal physiological need.

But being discovered was another story entirely.

So she immediately put away her phone.

Liang Shi lay there thinking: How to get through this long night?

Her body was only touching the edge of the bed. Although this bed was large enough, she was still afraid that Xu Qingzhu might sleep restlessly and like to roll around in bed, so she left plenty of space for her.

She was usually someone who slept very peacefully. Wherever she was positioned before sleeping, she would still be in the same place when she woke up.

Her thoughts were still in chaos, but she still couldn't resist her body's natural sleepiness.

Before she could figure out what to eat for breakfast tomorrow, she had already fallen asleep.

Footnotes:

¹ Empty shots (空镜) - Cinematographic technique where the camera focuses on scenery or objects without characters, often used to transition between scenes or imply action without showing it directly.

² Buddhist (佛系) - Modern Chinese slang meaning having a calm, peaceful, non-competitive attitude toward life, like a Buddhist monk's detached approach to worldly matters.

Chapter 25-6

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The next morning.

Sunlight poured into the room, spreading across the bed, somewhat glaring. Liang Shi was awakened by the brightness.

She picked up her phone to check the time - 8:20.

It was time to get up, but Xu Qingzhu was still sleeping, as if trying to make up for all the sleep she hadn't gotten before.

Liang Shi was afraid the sunlight would disturb her, so she got up and pulled the curtains tighter.

The room immediately fell back into dimness.

Liang Shi had always maintained good sleep habits.

When not filming, she would get up around eight in the morning, exercise for a while, eat breakfast, then watch shows or read books. In the afternoon, she would sit on the balcony drinking afternoon tea, spending a relaxed and pleasant day.

When she got up, there was no one else at home. The common areas had already been cleaned by the servants, spotless.

She went to the kitchen to pour herself a glass of water, then took bread from the refrigerator and cracked an egg into the breakfast machine.

She planned to make sandwiches.

If conditions allowed, she would definitely eat breakfast.

Just as she was busy in the kitchen, Xu Qingya's voice suddenly rang out: "Sister Liang, you can cook too?"

Liang Shi's fried egg was just perfectly medium, still with a runny yolk. She stole a moment from her busyness to look back, only to see Xu Qingya with messy hair, not caring about her appearance at all. She yawned widely and reached for the bread, taking a bite before Liang Shi could say anything.

"That's cold," Liang Shi said.

Unfortunately, she said it a step too late.

Xu Qingya didn't mind though, "It's fine, as long as it's edible."

Liang Shi: "..."

Alright then.

"Where's my sister?" Xu Qingya asked, "Not awake yet?"

"Mm." Liang Shi said: "The doctor said last night that she might sleep for a day and night."

Xu Qingya shook her head, "She's really become Sleeping Beauty."

She bit into the piece of bread while playing on her phone. After a while, she looked up and asked: "Sister Liang, what are you making? Make me one too, I'm a bit hungry."

Liang Shi answered without looking back: "Sandwich, it'll be ready soon."

As she spoke, she had already wrapped one up and handed it to Xu Qingya, then started making her own portion.

Xu Qingya took a bite, originally not expecting much from Liang Shi's cooking skills. After all, sandwiches were like scrambled eggs with tomatoes - it was nearly impossible to make them taste terrible, but making them taste really good wasn't very likely either.

But as soon as this entered her mouth, Xu Qingya was shocked.

At first she wasn't sure, thinking maybe she was just too hungry, so she was having the illusion that this thing was fresh and delicious.

But she quickly took two more bites, and only after swallowing everything did she say: "Sister Liang, did you really make this?"

Liang Shi laughed helplessly, "You were sitting here the whole time, how could I cheat?"

"No, this is too delicious." Xu Qingya gave her a thumbs up, "This cooking skill can rival a five-star chef. What did you use? Why does it taste so fresh? So fresh I want to bite off my own tongue."

Liang Shi felt her praise was too exaggerated.

Liang Shi was somewhat confident about her cooking skills - after all, she had worked in kitchens for many years - but suddenly facing such high praise, it seemed she couldn't accept it.

"Just ordinary method," Liang Shi said: "Fried egg, lettuce, cheese, tomato, and a little sauce."

"Better than anything I've eaten before." Xu Qingya praised sincerely, "This makes me want to live at your house permanently."

Liang Shi: "..."

Please don't.

But she couldn't say that honestly, so she put on a kind appearance: "You can stay, as long as you want."

After a pause, she added a condition: "As long as your sister lets you stay."

Xu Qingya: "Tsk."

Liang Shi quickly finished making her own sandwich and sat there chatting casually with Xu Qingya.

Mainly Xu Qingya was chatting with her, and she was responsible for responding.

Xu Qingya was quite a talkative little girl. When discussing idol culture, her eyes would light up.

She also said her dream was to become an agent.

But after saying that, she was somewhat silent, pausing before saying: "Forget it, I should change my dream."

"Why?" Liang Shi was puzzled.

Xu Qingya sighed, "Sister Weiwei is an agent. A lot of Chen Zhengxuan's merchandise was gotten for me by her."

Liang Shi also understood her concerns, but could only offer lukewarm comfort: "Not all agents are like that."

But it did remind her of Bai Weiwei and Zhao Xuning.

After she left with Xu Qingzhu last night, she didn't see Zhao Xuning on the road, so she still didn't know how things went on Zhao Xuning's side.

Out of humanitarian spirit, after Liang Shi finished breakfast and put the dishes in the dishwasher, she sent Zhao Xuning a message asking about her situation.

After a long while, Zhao Xuning replied: [Not bad.]

Quite a perfunctory answer.

But Liang Shi had done her part.

After that, she didn't bother anymore.

In the morning, having nothing else to do, she began researching information about Dongheng Group, especially about the newly established magazine department.

Just as Liang Xinhe had said, this magazine department was a newly established division that hadn't even published a single issue yet. They only had an official Weibo account that hadn't posted anything, with ten thousand followers - probably bought followers.

Since they hadn't published anything, there was pitifully little information available online.

She then looked at other electronic publications, especially seeking experiences from companies similar to Dongheng Group that had started electronic magazines, trying to find some successful experiences.

During her research, she discovered that the first in the industry to do this was Haiwei Jewelry.

Clearly just a jewelry company, but they had advanced experience - not only creating electronic magazines but also establishing a first-class domestic fashion magazine - "Mingzhu" (Pearl).

In this era when print media had declined and the print media industry had become a sunset industry, with many major magazine companies shutting down one after another, and the remaining ones mostly operating at a loss or persisting with passion, "Mingzhu" had carved out a different path, focusing heavily on feminism and inviting renowned domestic writers to write editorials.

In a fashion magazine, there wasn't much written content, but every article in each issue was penetrating.

In the new media era, it could be said they achieved 100k+ readership in minutes.

But their magazine and electronic publication were done separately, with completely non-overlapping content.

Precisely because of this, the electronic publication didn't steal sales from the magazine.

The group of people running this magazine had never been in the magazine industry before - there were people from the fashion industry, designers, and even web novel writers.

So the industry's evaluation of "Mingzhu" magazine was: a group of third-rate people created a first-rate magazine.

Chapter 25-7

Liang Shi finished organizing all the materials by noon.

The housekeeper asked if she wanted lunch prepared. She was thinking about the menu in her head when she received a call from Liang Xinhe before she could figure it out.

She answered politely, "Second Brother."

"Where are you?" Liang Xinhe asked.

Liang Shi thought he was checking up on her, so she answered obediently: "At home."

"Chuanlan Villa?"

"Yes."

"What are you still doing there?" Liang Xinhe's tone was already somewhat impatient, "Liang Shi, I really thought you were going to turn over a new leaf, but you're still like this? It's one thing for you to fool around outside, but now you don't even want this family? Are you planning to sever ties with the Liang family?"

Liang Shi: "...?"

"Alright, what kind of way is that to talk to Shi?" A gentle female voice came through, "You're clearly worried about Shi and want to see her, but you use these words to hurt people. With this attitude of yours, you'll start arguing before saying a few words each time."

Liang Shi guessed this should be her second sister-in-law.

In the original book, Second Sister-in-law didn't have much screen time.

But she was a particularly positive character.

When the original owner was at her lowest point, she even gave the original owner some money, but that money was quickly lost by the original owner to gambling.

This led to her later targeting her daughter.

Liang Shi didn't know much more than that.

After all, she hadn't thoroughly read and memorized the entire text before transmigrating.

"Shi." Second Sister-in-law took over the phone, "You're supposed to return to the old residence today, right? Remember to bring your sister-in-law¹."

"Second Sister-in-law." Liang Shi's attitude was very good, "Zhuzi is sick and can't go back."

"Is it serious?" Second Sister-in-law asked with concern, "Then you stay home and take care of her. It's fine, I'll talk to Mom about it."

"How can you spoil her like this?" Liang Xinhe took back the phone, "Liang Shi, whatever you have going on today, you have to come back. What did you tell me last week? That even if knives were raining from the sky, you would still return to the old residence. Have you forgotten your own words?"

Liang Shi: "..."

That was what the original owner said.

Never mind.

She was the one now anyway.

"It's Big Brother's birthday today. You won't even come home for a meal? You might as well stop being surnamed Liang." Liang Xinhe said impatiently and hung up.

Liang Xinhe's temper was indeed somewhat quick.

But his heart was good.

Liang Shi didn't complain either. She told the housekeeper that today's lunch only needed to be made for Xu Qingya alone, while she had to return to the old residence.

Since it was Liang Xinzhou's birthday, Liang Shi had to go no matter what.

After all, she was still considered part of the Liang family for now.

It was just that the original owner's relationship with the family members was generally poor. With her troublemaking nature, she had probably caused trouble wherever she could.

In any case, it was a pile of messes.

//

Liang Shi didn't know the way to the old residence, so the driver took her back.

The old residence wasn't far from the villa, but it was obviously more luxurious and had more heritage. This area was full of villa estates.

It had quite the flavor of ancient times when people occupied mountains as kings.

The Liang family's building was Gothic style, which was quite distinctive among all these villas.

As soon as her car entered the courtyard, someone came out to greet her.

When she got out of the car, the servant bowed and extended her arm, "Third Miss."

Liang Shi placed her hand on the servant's arm and got out of the car.

The entrance had elaborate architectural details, giving one the feeling of accidentally entering a museum. It was clear that the Liang family had spent quite a bit of money building this residence.

Two rows of female servants stood at the entrance. As she walked past, they bowed in unison and respectfully called out: "Third Miss."

Quite impressive.

Because she was returning to the old residence, Liang Shi had specifically gone to buy appropriate clothing.

She couldn't really accept the clothes in the original owner's closet.

Today she wore a light apricot long dress with a white suit jacket, her long hair down, and silver earrings.

Slightly bright makeup, but not overly luxurious, paired with the minimalist style white suit - low-key yet not showing disrespect.

After she entered, Second Sister-in-law was the first to notice her. Second Sister-in-law smiled and stood up, "Shi is back."

At the gilded long table, everyone had already taken their seats. Although there was still a place at the table, the extra tableware had been removed, and everyone had already assumed she wouldn't come back.

Father Liang was over sixty, in good health, sitting in the main seat. Seeing her, he only hummed lightly, "You still know to come back."

Liang Shi said awkwardly, "Sorry, I got busy and forgot."

Her tone showed clear distance.

She actually wanted to establish good relationships with these people, but unfortunately, she had never had family for so many years and really didn't know how to get along with family members. She could only try to be as polite as possible.

Moreover, everyone was used to the original owner's unrestrained style.

But the original owner was relatively well-behaved at home.

So Liang Shi didn't reveal any flaws.

She just stood there, somewhat awkwardly.

No one told her to sit, and except for Second Sister-in-law, no one else greeted her either. The girl sitting at the edge with pure features pursed her lips and said, "Third Sister."

"Mm." Liang Shi smiled at her, "Wanwan, have you started school?"

Liang Wanwan was the youngest sister in the family, just starting her junior year of college. Her personality was much more likeable than the original owner's.

"Not yet." Liang Wanwan said: "The day after tomorrow."

Liang Shi nodded.

Awkward conversation was indeed difficult.

Especially in such an almost completely unfamiliar situation, it was purely a technical skill.

"What are you all standing around for? Get Third Miss her tableware." Liang Xinhe finally spoke up, "Each one of you, don't you have any sense?"

The servants immediately went to get them, and another servant pulled out a chair for Liang Shi.

Liang Shi sat down. Across from her was a little girl.

Probably three or four years old, wearing a pink hair clip, looking at her with timid eyes.

She should be Liang Xinhe's daughter.

Second Sister-in-law taught her, "Lingdang, greet your aunt."

The child bit her lip and after a while called out: "Aunt."

Liang Shi smiled, "Mm, long time no see, you've gotten even prettier."

The little girl's expression relaxed slightly.

Liang Shi had been observing her expression. She had originally thought the original owner shouldn't have done anything to such a small girl, but now she felt that she probably hadn't spared even such a small child, making the kid still watch her face carefully.

She tried to make her smile as gentle as possible.

Today was Liang Xinzhou's birthday. She recognized this eldest brother at first glance when she came in.

A typical business elite, wearing a black suit and glasses, with a cold beauty sitting beside him - the eldest sister-in-law.

Qiu Zimin sat together with Father Liang, both in the main seats.

Probably because they had argued on the phone before, when she saw her today, she didn't have a good expression either, her eyes gloomy.

Liang Shi didn't deliberately try to please her either.

Anyway, she would eventually break ties with the Liang family. She just needed to wait until the Liang family found their biological daughter, and her connection with this place would be over.

Now it was just going through the motions. It was clear that everyone in this family didn't really welcome her back.

Although Liang Xinzhou and Liang Xinhe were both married, they had always lived in the old residence without establishing separate households.

Only she had moved to Chuanlan Villa immediately after marriage.

Was it because there wasn't enough room?

Certainly not.

Such a large residence could accommodate everyone even if Liang Wanwan got married and they all lived together.

With so many servants, they could all be taken care of.

It was simply because they didn't like her and wanted her to move out.

But this was understandable. The original owner would cause trouble outside from time to time. Father Liang had always been strict about disciplining children, so father and daughter would have conflicts.

Footnotes:

¹ "Sister-in-law" (妹妻) - Literally "younger sister's wife," referring to Xu Qingzhu as the wife of Liang Shi (who is the youngest daughter in the family).

Chapter 25-8

The dishes on the table were delicious, and Liang Shi also politely only touched the one or two dishes in front of her.

There was a crystal aspic in front of her. Seeing the little girl across from her staring at it longingly, she originally didn't want to meddle, but because the little girl's eyes looked so pitiful, she couldn't help herself and used the serving chopsticks to put some in the little girl's bowl.

Although Lingdang liked this dish, because it was served by Liang Shi, she wasn't sure whether she should eat it.

She looked at Liang Shi hesitantly, and Liang Shi gave her a gentle smile, "Go ahead and eat."

Second Sister-in-law beside her also patted her head, "What should Lingdang say?"

Lingdang was clever and smiled: "Thank you, Aunt."

Liang Shi was unconsciously infected by her smile, and her tone became lighter too, "It's nothing."

Children generally don't hold grudges.

If you treat them slightly better, even if there were unpleasant incidents before, they'll forget about them.

Lingdang was just like that.

After that, Liang Shi helped her with dishes several more times, and her voice became even sweeter.

Second Sister-in-law even said: "Shi, eat your own food, don't worry about her."

"It's fine, I'm full." Liang Shi said: "I had breakfast."

It was only just past twelve o'clock now. She had eaten a sandwich around nine, and hadn't done any strenuous exercise afterward, so she wasn't very hungry.

Second Sister-in-law didn't say anything more.

But Liang Xinhe turned to look at her and said quietly: "What a transformation, even getting up early now."

Liang Shi: "..."

She suspected this second brother couldn't speak without being sarcastic.

But at the dinner table, she didn't retort either, just shrugged to indicate yes.

This topic was just brushed aside like that.

This meal was somewhat oppressive. Although they were supposedly eating a reunion dinner to celebrate Liang Xinzhou's birthday, everyone at the table didn't talk much. It wasn't lively at all, and was even quiet enough that you could hear the sound of chopsticks touching plates.

Liang Shi felt even more like she had thorns on her back¹.

It must be the karma from the original owner being too high-profile.

When she was eating, the servants' gazes were probably all focused on her.

After the meal, Father Liang chatted with Liang Xinzhou and Liang Xinhe about company matters for a while.

The others sat there doing their own things, in various poses.

Later, Father Liang suggested that the family go play golf. There was a huge golf course behind the villa.

Liang Shi followed along to see what it was like.

Her golf was mediocre. To be precise, she wasn't very good at any ball sports.

From what she knew, the original owner wasn't very good either.

Although she was an Alpha, she often didn't exercise.

She didn't even have abs.

She idly wasted the entire afternoon until after five o'clock, when everyone finally returned indoors together.

Dinner was at seven. Father Liang said he was tired now and wanted to return to his room to rest.

Everyone else also went back to their respective rooms.

Liang Shi finally figured out the pattern - everything in this house was decided by Father Liang.

Qiu Zimin was very silent in front of Father Liang, nothing like the talkative person she had been on the phone before. Even the occasional glances she cast carried some awe and fear.

This wasn't normal.

Everything in this house was abnormal.

Although Liang Shi had lost her parents very early, she had lived with her grandparents before high school.

Normal families wouldn't have this kind of atmosphere.

It was like a strictly hierarchical institution.

Liang Shi pondered while returning to the bedroom.

The original owner's bedroom was on the innermost side of the third floor, with a password lock.

She entered the password, pushed open the door, and was stunned.

This bedroom was very dark - not the kind of darkness caused by external light, but a gloomy darkness.

The bedroom was airtight, with all the windows completely covered by curtains, but there was a fluorescent golden totem on the opposite wall - a wolf.

It looked especially like some kind of ritual².

She pressed the light switch and found that all the walls were black, and the carpet, bed sheets, quilt, and pillows were all black.

In the huge room, there were no extra decorations. The only thing that could be considered decoration was the lamp by the bedside.

But even the lamp's appearance was black.

The room's lighting wasn't bright incandescent bulbs or warm yellow light, but an indescribable, somewhat eerie spotlight.

More like the kind of lighting commonly seen in bars and clubs.

She pressed the switch several more times, and the lighting changed several times, but none were normal.

The most normal one was probably very dim, but could barely illuminate the entire room.

She suppressed the shock in her heart, walked into the room, and after closing the door, she actually felt a chill down her back.

So she went over to pull open the curtains, but she discovered that the curtains were just for show.

Behind the curtains was a wall, and on the wall were crisscrossing carved marks, with some writing stained with blood, looking very much like mystical symbols³.

This was a room without windows. According to Liang Shi's personality, why would she live in such a room?

There were many vacant rooms here, so why give her a room without windows?

And this room's decoration was too sinister, wasn't it?

Did Liang Shi decorate it like this herself, or did her family decorate it for her?

When she came up earlier, Lingdang had pulled her to the left side of the third floor. Through the slightly open door crack, she saw that Lingdang's room was very normal, with bright tones, warm and comfortable.

Liang Xinhe's room was also normal business person style.

Only the original owner's was like this.

Liang Shi didn't dare lie down on that bed, but now this was the only place where she could stay quietly.

So before dinner, she still had to stay in this room.

She might as well take this opportunity to look for any diary or similar things the original owner might have left behind.

Don't protagonists usually love writing diaries?

In the original owner's room closet, there was a neat pile of flashy clothes. She rummaged through them but didn't find anything. The bedside table was obviously empty at a glance, but in the bottom drawer she found two packs of cigarettes.

Just ordinary brands available on the market.

She searched the entire room but didn't find anything useful.

Getting a bit tired from searching, she simply sat on the carpet.

Looking up at the ceiling.

This room's ceiling construction was also different from ordinary ones. It was pure black, not a very flat shape, but that kind of downward-curving arch.

Liang Shi found it familiar, but couldn't say specifically where she'd seen it.

Her phone vibrated, and she took it out to look.

It was a browser notification with the headline: "Mountain Village Female Corpse Mysteriously Disappears, What Amazing Secret Lies Behind It!"

Total clickbait, but that picture attracted her attention.

Because the accompanying image was an opened coffin.

And this room's ceiling actually had striking similarities to that image.

Both were downward-curving arches, practically an enlarged version of the picture.

Footnotes:

¹ "Like she had thorns on her back" (如芒在背) - Chinese idiom meaning to feel very uncomfortable, as if being watched or criticized.

² "Ritual" (做法) - Refers to mystical or supernatural rituals, often associated with witchcraft or occult practices.

³ "Mystical symbols" (鬼畫符) - Literally "ghost drawings" or "demon talismans," referring to mysterious symbols that look like occult markings.

Chapter 25-9

Liang Shi found the indoor lighting too dim, so she simply turned on her phone's flashlight and pointed it at the ceiling, discovering a string of characters behind the lamp.

She couldn't see them very clearly.

She suddenly remembered something in the original owner's phone memo, which had an entry: [Sacrifice. Heh.]

It was hard not to connect such a room with sacrifice.

But coincidentally, this worldview background also didn't advocate feudal superstition.

Liang Shi was completely puzzled.

Just as she was deep in thought, she suddenly felt a headache.

It was like thousands of ants biting, but this headache only lasted a few seconds.

Then a segment of unfamiliar memory entered her mind.

Students in school uniforms, people wandering around campus, tall buildings, all kinds of people, and lecture halls.

Too many scenes to sort through.

Having experienced previous events, Liang Shi's adaptability was very strong.

She quickly sorted through this memory.

To be precise, there were two segments of memory.

One related to Xu Qingzhu, one related to Zhou Yi'an.

The original owner had noticed Xu Qingzhu during university.

Xu Qingzhu attended the best university in the country - Qingyi University, which was three streets away from the original owner's diploma mill.

The original owner had encountered Xu Qingzhu and Bai Weiwei by chance at a street corner and immediately became interested in Xu Qingzhu, but unlike her previous bold approach to flirting, she adopted a very subtle method instead.

She had someone get Xu Qingzhu's class schedule and went to audit classes at that university.

Going to Qingyi University's library, cafeteria, appearing everywhere she could possibly see Xu Qingzhu, but never directly approaching her for conversation.

It was hard to call this liking.

But the scenes in those memories were indeed centered around Xu Qingzhu.

Later, on the night of the original owner's graduation, everyone gathered for a beach barbecue. She shouted at the ocean, "I really want to get married!"

Everyone laughed, and the matter passed.

In the year after graduation, Second Brother arranged work for her, but she didn't go.

Later he gave her a nominal position as Deputy Director of Human Resources, which she attended for a few days before losing interest. She spent her days fooling around with Cheng Ran and others, living wildly.

But one day, hearing that the Xu family business was in crisis, she went to talk to Xu Qingzhu without a second thought.

To marry Xu Qingzhu, she negotiated with Father Liang, with Qiu Zimin, and even humbled herself to beg Liang Xinhe.

It was Liang Xinhe and Qiu Zimin acting as mediators that allowed her to marry Xu Qingzhu.

But after marrying Xu Qingzhu, she indeed continued to live wildly.

Staying out all night was the norm.

After not touching Xu Qingzhu on their wedding night, when she later wanted to touch her, Xu Qingzhu wouldn't let her, so she ended up ordering her around imperiously.

The events after that were no different from what she had previously understood.

Having this memory, Liang Shi found it even harder to understand the original owner's behavior. Why, if she clearly liked Xu Qingzhu, would she treat her that way?

If she didn't like her and it was just possessiveness, why would she pay such a high price to marry her?

Could it be that she enjoyed the feeling of obtaining something and then destroying it with her own hands?

This was probably the most extreme speculation.

She had no way to find the original owner and ask: What exactly were you thinking?

She could only say that the original owner's thoughts were too strange.

Worth mentioning was the past with Zhou Yi'an.

So when Zhou Yi'an said "nice to see you again" upon meeting her, it was because they had interacted before, and not shallowly.

The original owner and Zhou Yi'an were from the same high school, when everyone hadn't yet differentiated.

Compared to the original owner's arrogant behavior, Zhou Yi'an was no less outrageous.

But at that time, the Zhou family didn't have such circumstances. Zhou's father was posted elsewhere, and no matter how long his reach, he couldn't extend it to Haizou, so even if Zhou Yi'an was arrogant, she didn't dare bully schoolmates. Instead, she extended her claws to middle school students. Unfortunately, her favorite target was the original owner's sister, Liang Wanwan.

The original owner initially didn't know about this, and Liang Wanwan didn't dare tell her.

Later, someone used this to mock her, and only then did she learn about it. That very day she went to find Zhou Yi'an, and when she arrived, she found Zhou Yi'an bullying Liang Wanwan. Without a word, she punched Zhou Yi'an.

That day she severely beat Zhou Yi'an.

From then on, Zhou Yi'an no longer bullied Liang Wanwan, but instead targeted the original owner.

Zhou Yi'an would often say then, "Baby, you've caught my interest."

The original owner had a fiery temper, and the two often fought, but the more they fought, the brighter Zhou Yi'an's eyes became.

But not long after, Zhou Yi'an transferred to a high school abroad.

Who would have thought that after all these years, Zhou's father had been successfully promoted, the Liang family had fallen, and their positions were completely reversed.

Zhou Yi'an no longer needed to fear the Liang family; instead, the Liang family had to look at the Zhou family's face and get benefits from them, so Zhou Yi'an could act without restraint.

It turned out that even wealthy families had hierarchies.

The Liang family's position could only be said to be decent, but couldn't yet be called the top of the food chain.

Liang Shi sighed inwardly.

She never imagined that the original owner and Zhou Yi'an had such an intersection.

But she was puzzled why staying in the original owner's room would trigger new memory infusions.

Was it some kind of mechanism? Or accumulated time?

She tried both methods but found nothing special, and no new memories came.

After sorting out her thoughts in the room, Liang Shi left this place.

It was too gloomy and oppressive.

//

After going downstairs, Liang Shi saw Lingdang, who was curled up on the sofa watching TV.

Seeing her come down, she smiled and called: "Aunt."

Liang Shi responded and then watched TV with her for a while.

Soon, the Liang family members came downstairs together.

Dinner was even more sumptuous than lunch, with a cake in the center, but no one played around or smeared frosting. They just quietly ate the cake, as if going through a procedure.

The evening atmosphere was even more oppressive than lunch.

Liang Shi still didn't eat much and continued taking care of Lingdang.

After dinner, Lingdang had already started clinging to her.

Nestling in her arms, playing little games with her.

Chapter 25-10

When it was past eight o'clock, Liang Shi got up to prepare to leave.

She had just stepped out the door and hadn't yet gotten in the car when Qiu Zimin called out to her, "Shi, wait."

Liang Shi turned around, her brow slightly furrowed, her tone cold: "What is it?"

She didn't think she and Qiu Zimin had anything left to discuss.

"You've read the text messages Mom sent you, right?" Qiu Zimin asked her, but there was some probing in her words, "Why didn't you reply to Mom? Haven't you forgiven Mom yet?"

The wind was picking up outside. Liang Shi gathered her white suit jacket and tucked her scattered hair behind her ear, "What do you want to say?"

"Nothing." Qiu Zimin's tone was heavy, "Mom didn't do it on purpose either. The family is carrying such a heavy burden, your father's white hair has increased, and the southern plot of land is crucial for our family. Whether we can restore our former glory depends on this opportunity. Yi'an truly likes you, and didn't you also want to divorce that one from the Xu family..."

"When did I say I wanted a divorce?" Liang Shi interrupted her words, "When I married Xu Qingzhu, I made it clear that you only needed to handle that one time, and you don't need to manage anything afterward."

Having recovered some memories, Liang Shi spoke with more confidence.

"Then you and Yi'an..." Qiu Zimin paused.

Liang Shi answered firmly, "Not possible."

"But Liang Shi, have you forgotten who fed you, clothed you, and raised you all these years?" Qiu Zimin's expression immediately changed. In her eyes, there was no trace of guilt, and the previous submissiveness seemed like Liang Shi's illusion.

"Even if it was you, you don't have the right to interfere with my marriage at will." Liang Shi said: "Making me undergo surgery to be with Zhou Yi'an - you really came up with that idea."

Qiu Zimin snorted coldly, "Many people are doing this now. How am I harming you? In the future, with the Zhou family as support, it won't be a waste of all these years raising you. Besides, you could live better than you do now."

"This issue is not necessary for us to discuss." Liang Shi said, "I won't do this, and you'd better stay away from Zhou Yi'an too. That person is very dangerous."

Actually, very evil.

Because you never knew what a psychologically twisted person would do.

"I've eaten more salt than you've eaten rice¹, and I'm better at judging people than you. That Xu Qingzhu is not a peaceful person and will definitely harm you greatly in the future." Qiu Zimin said: "What's wrong with Zhou Yi'an?"

"You just have your eye on the Zhou family." Liang Shi exposed her lie.

Liang Shi stared straight at her and suddenly asked in a low voice: "Are you still my mother?"

Qiu Zimin's eyes flickered, then she said firmly: "You came from my belly, how could I not be your mother? Liang Shi, I'm thinking of you. If you don't want to listen, then forget it. Even though the Liang family has accommodated you in everything all these years, I've indulged and spoiled you, and everyone says my daughter is no good and worthless, but I never believed it. I knew my daughter was good, my daughter was obedient, it's just that they couldn't see it. Now thinking about it, I should have been wrong."

"No matter what, it's your choice. Mom is just making a suggestion. If you don't like it, I won't say it anymore." Qiu Zimin said: "The Liang family's decline is inevitable. Who told me I didn't raise good children? In the future when I die, I won't be able to face the Liang family ancestors."

Liang Shi: "..."

These lines were so familiar.

Liang Shi had once acted in a drama about PUA².

The male character paid money to take classes specifically to PUA wealthy girls, undermining their confidence, making them unable to leave him, spending money on him, finding jobs for him, and having to appease him submissively.

Qiu Zimin's current rhetoric was identical to PUA tactics.

First came the put-down, saying you're really terrible, your existence is harm to this world, then she would say, but I believe in you, I'm the only one in this world who treats you well, so you can trust me, everything I ask you to do is for your own good.

Over time, the other person would become a puppet that could be manipulated at will.

In more serious cases, they might become depressed or mentally unstable.

Liang Shi just looked at Qiu Zimin coldly. After she finished speaking, she lightly asked back: "Anything else?"

"Mom transferred money to you." Qiu Zimin said, "You don't have a job either, and the house you live in was bought by us. Although you don't want to compromise, I am your mother after all, and I can't not care about you. Take this money and spend it. It's cold, drive slowly when you go back."

Liang Shi: "Oh."

She got in the car, then rolled down the window and said to Qiu Zimin: "I'll be working at Dongheng from now on, so you don't need to give me living expenses. Also, Chuanlan Villa belongs to you, I'm just temporarily living there. When I have money, I'll move out."

Qiu Zimin's expression twisted for a moment, but she forced a smile: "What are you saying? Can I not care about my own daughter? You're still young and don't have much earning ability..."

"I'm already married." Liang Shi said: "I will take on the corresponding responsibilities."

She looked at Qiu Zimin, "So, don't think about controlling me anymore."

The car drove out of the old residence villa.

Qiu Zimin stood at the door, her hands clutching her coat, her eyes containing towering fury.

After a long while, Qiu Zimin gritted her teeth and spat out two words: "Waste."

Footnotes:

¹ "I've eaten more salt than you've eaten rice" (我吃過的鹽比你吃過的飯都多) - A Chinese idiom meaning "I have more life experience than you."

² PUA - "Pick-up Artist," referring to manipulative tactics used to control and exploit others emotionally, often in romantic contexts.

Chapter 25-11

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When Liang Shi returned to Chuanlan Villa, it was already past nine o'clock.

Xu Qingya was sitting in the living room playing games. When she saw her come back, she looked up and greeted her.

"Where's your sister?" Liang Shi asked.

Xu Qingya said: "Still sleeping."

She stood up and walked toward her room, "Sister Liang, I'm going back to my room."

"Okay." Liang Shi responded.

She first went to the kitchen to pour herself a glass of water, then came out and looked at the living room, feeling that this kind of decorating style and color scheme was still more comfortable to look at. That room in the old residence looked spine-chilling just to see.

After spacing out downstairs for a while, she returned to her room.

Xu Qingzhu was still not awake. She had been sleeping for a very long time.

Liang Shi returned to the room, took a shower, and played mobile games while waiting for her hair to dry. Later, too tired, she lay down and fell asleep before her hair was completely dry.

But she didn't sleep very soundly, probably because she had been frightened by the original owner's bedroom decoration during the day.

She actually dreamed about coffins.

In the pitch-black night, a coffin was flying around, and paper money was floating in the sky.

There was also a Taoist priest who stuck a talisman on her forehead, which immediately woke her up with fright.

She suddenly opened her eyes, only to meet a pair of bright eyes.

This startled Liang Shi so much that her heart almost stopped beating, and only then did she realize it was Xu Qingzhu.

She let out a soft breath, her voice somewhat hoarse: "What are you doing?"

"Did you have a nightmare?" Xu Qingzhu asked.

Liang Shi nodded, "Did you touch my face?"

Xu Qingzhu turned her face away, looking at her forehead, her voice as cold as always: "No."

Then she got out of bed.

She asked: "How long did I sleep?"

Liang Shi answered: "A day and a night."

"What about Weiwei?"

"Zhao Xuning went to pick her up, she should be fine." Liang Shi reached over to turn on the bedside lamp and also lit up her phone screen, discovering it was already past eleven o'clock.

She had briefly slept and had such a vivid dream that she now had no sleepiness at all.

"Last night we..." Xu Qingzhu paused, then rephrased more gently: "Did anything happen?"

Liang Shi immediately shook her head, "No, nothing at all."

Then Liang Shi suddenly realized, "You don't remember anything?"

Xu Qingzhu frowned slightly and answered honestly: "My memory stops after drinking a large glass of white liquor."

Liang Shi: "..."

Good heavens, so she was someone who blacks out when she drinks too much.

"You don't remember anything? Not even tiny fragments?" Liang Shi didn't know what hope she was harboring.

After all, last night's Xu Qingzhu had been particularly amusing. If she remembered, it would probably be a major scene of social death.

"Nothing." Xu Qingzhu pressed her forehead, "Was it you who brought me out of there last night?"

"Zhao Xuning and I." Liang Shi didn't take credit, "It was Zhao Xuning who got someone to open the private room door."

Actually, at that time, Liang Shi felt completely useless and couldn't do anything.

But thinking about it later, her original world was incompatible with this place, and she hadn't fully integrated into this world yet.

Moreover, like the original owner, when something happened, she was isolated and helpless. It was really difficult for her to face such high-level challenges.

She only hoped that she wouldn't encounter such situations again in the future.

"Thank you." Xu Qingzhu lowered her head and nodded, sitting on one side of the bed in a daze.

She was still wearing her previous clothes.

A camisole and long pants, reeking of alcohol.

After a while, she belatedly realized, "I should take a shower."

Liang Shi asked: "Are you hungry?"

Xu Qingzhu walked to the bathroom door, her steps pausing as she considered: "Would it be troublesome to cook now?"

"The servants are probably all asleep." Xu Qingzhu said: "I'm not too hungry..."

Before she finished speaking, her stomach started growling.

Xu Qingzhu was slightly embarrassed, and Liang Shi chuckled lightly, "It's fine, I didn't eat much tonight either. I'll make something simple for us to eat together."

"You can cook?" Xu Qingzhu raised her eyebrows in surprise.

Liang Shi nodded, "A little."

"Alright." Xu Qingzhu said: "Thank you for the trouble."

"You take a shower first, and I'll bring it up after I make it." Liang Shi said: "Your sister is still downstairs, afraid of disturbing her."

Xu Qingzhu was surprised by her thoughtfulness, but found it very agreeable: "Okay, thank you."

"You're welcome."

Liang Shi gave her the space, then went downstairs to cook noodles.

Relatively speaking, noodles were the simplest and also very suitable for someone who had just woken up after sleeping for a long time.

While staying upstairs, Xu Qingzhu found her phone before taking a shower and discovered it was fully charged. But when she left earlier, her phone only had 40% battery. Liang Shi must have charged it for her.

She had many such small considerate details.

For example, Xu Qingzhu had just discovered that she had been sleeping on the edge of the bed, just enough space for her body, and she would fall off if she wasn't careful.

Even though there was so much space left on the bed.

Also, when she went to cook, she didn't say it was purely for her, but said she was hungry and would cook for her as well, which would greatly reduce her sense of guilt.

Xu Qingzhu held her phone and pondered for two seconds, then called Bai Weiwei - phone was off.

She called Zhao Xuning - line was busy.

Neither of these two would answer their phones.

Chapter 25-12

Xu Qingzhu sent a text message to Zhao Xuning: [Is Weiwei okay? Has anything happened? Please contact me immediately if there's any news.]

After sending it, she went to take a shower.

That night, she had gone to Huayue International after receiving a text from Bai Weiwei.

She knew that wasn't a good place - Liang Shi and Cheng Ran used to go there often - but the text Bai Weiwei sent her that day was: [Come quickly, emergency!]

She didn't think too much about it and went, only to find Bai Weiwei sitting there drinking with investors. When Bai Weiwei saw her arrive, she was also surprised. The two compared their messages and discovered that Bai Weiwei hadn't sent her any message.

One of the bosses admitted that he had used Bai Weiwei's phone to send Xu Qingzhu the message. He had long heard that Haizou's number one Omega was as beautiful as a celestial fairy, but had never had the fortune to meet her, so he borrowed this opportunity to invite her for a drink.

Hearing this, Bai Weiwei became anxious and tried to leave with Xu Qingzhu.

Bai Weiwei was originally a wealthy young lady. Her family wasn't extremely rich, but they ran a technology company and weren't worried about food and clothing. She had become an agent after graduation because she personally liked the industry. When her temper flared up that time, she started arguing with that person.

A bunch of people around them started trying to mediate.

That drinking party didn't only have Bai Weiwei and Xu Qingzhu as female Omegas, and since all the attendees were influential big shots in the industry, Bai Weiwei didn't make a scene.

But later, their alcohol-pouring techniques were too sophisticated, and they started playing a drinking game. Originally, they said they could leave after playing two rounds, but Bai Weiwei's luck was too bad - she collapsed after just one round, while Xu Qingzhu fared slightly better but still didn't make it past the second round.

They weren't people who were good at drinking to begin with, and having just passed her heat cycle, her body was in a vulnerable period, so she got drunk easily.

Especially after getting drunk, she had particularly severe blackouts - the kind where she truly couldn't remember anything at all.

She didn't think much about it, even speculating that her outer clothing had been removed because she had vomited on it from drinking too much, and Liang Shi had helped her take it off.

She didn't feel anything was inappropriate about it.

When she came out after showering, Liang Shi had already returned to the room, and the room was filled with the aroma of noodles.

She took a look - it was quite presentable.

Two large bowls, with just the right proportion of noodles and broth in each bowl, a layer of golden oil floating on the soup, and green scallions sprinkled on top of the noodles. It looked very appetizing.

Liang Shi handed her chopsticks, "Make do with this. We'll eat something better tomorrow morning. You shouldn't eat too much right now either."

Xu Qingzhu accepted them, "Thank you."

Liang Shi was also truly hungry. She hadn't eaten much at lunch or dinner.

In that atmosphere at the Liang family, it was hard to eat.

Now holding a bowl of steaming hot noodles, she felt all the gluttons in her stomach being awakened.

The room suddenly became quiet. Even though both were extremely hungry, they didn't make slurping sounds, but ate their noodles unhurriedly.

When she was almost finished, Xu Qingzhu discovered two poached eggs lying in the broth. She bit into one - the yolk was just set, not dry at all.

She looked at Liang Shi, "Did you make eggs for yourself?"

"No." Liang Shi said: "I had some this morning. My nutrition is already supplemented, I don't need more."

"So you gave me your portion?" Xu Qingzhu said.

Liang Shi smiled, "How could that be? They're all yours."

Xu Qingzhu finished all the food in her bowl, satisfied and full, and wiped her lips with a tissue.

The tissue brushed past her bright red lips as she looked at Liang Shi, "How did you suddenly learn to cook?"

Liang Shi: "..."

Here we go again.

The sisters' tactics were exactly the same.

The younger sister fishing, the older sister probing.

Liang Shi smiled, "Cooking is such a simple thing, isn't it just a matter of having hands?"

Xu Qingzhu put on a look of sudden realization, drawing out her voice: "Oh~"

Liang Shi got up to clean up the aftermath, but was pressed down by Xu Qingzhu, "You cooked, I'll clean up."

"No need, you just recovered from illness, let me do it." Liang Shi said: "Zhao Xuning said you need to rest quietly. If you don't recover properly and end up back in the hospital, Zhao Xuning will definitely beat me up."

Xu Qingzhu found this amusing, "Is she that scary?"

Liang Shi nodded, "Very scary."

She cleaned up quickly, put everything in the dishwasher downstairs, and hurried back upstairs.

Xu Qingzhu was changing the bed sheets.

She helped finish it together, then said: "Please help me get a quilt. I don't know where they're kept, so I slept on the bed last night."

Xu Qingzhu paused, not understanding: "This is your room, your bed. It's only natural for you to sleep on it, right? You don't need to explain it to me."

Liang Shi: "..."

That seemed to make sense.

But the system made her humble.

"It's fine." Liang Shi said: "I'm an Alpha, so I can sleep on the floor. You sleep on the bed. It was like this the whole time your sister was here."

Xu Qingzhu's bed-making movements were very skillful. She threw the changed sheets and pillowcases into the basket while talking: "Didn't we already discuss this issue before? You sleep on the bed."

Liang Shi shook her head, "That won't work. You just recovered from illness. How could I possibly let you sleep on the floor..."

Xu Qingzhu stood on the opposite side of the bed, looking at Liang Shi openly and honestly: "Who said I was going to sleep on the floor?"

Liang Shi: "...?"

Before she could react to the implications of Xu Qingzhu's words, a mechanical voice suddenly rang in her mind:

[Ding dong! Congratulations host, you have accumulated 20 lucky points. You are rewarded 10,000 yuan, which will be deposited into your account in ten minutes.

At the same time, you have triggered a passive task: watch a movie with Xu Qingzhu.

Note: Completing the passive task will reduce the currently accumulated bad luck points. Failure to complete it will result in a deduction of 1-3 lucky points.

PS: The little system has noticed that the host has been performing well recently, so this is an encouragement. Please keep up the good work! Fighting!]

Liang Shi: "..."

If I'm performing well, why don't you add two points?

What's the use of verbal rewards?

But this brought her slight comfort.

Finally, she had accumulated 20 lucky points.

But that passive task was also quite troublesome.

Watching a movie wasn't a big deal, but she would lose points if she didn't complete it. This system was really shameless.

Liang Shi was once again speechless about this system.

But this didn't change her current predicament.

She still had to continue being controlled by this system.

Chapter 25-13

Just as Liang Shi was lost in thought, Xu Qingzhu had already laid out two quilts on the bed, "The bed is so big, can't we both sleep on it?"

Liang Shi: "..."

"It's possible, but..." Liang Shi had never slept in the same bed with a woman. The previous two days were an accident - she had never even touched Xu Qingzhu while on the bed. But sleeping like this now would inevitably lead to physical contact.

This...

"Aren't you afraid I might do something inappropriate to you?" Liang Shi asked.

Xu Qingzhu stared into her eyes, "Would you?"

Liang Shi: "...No."

"Then that settles it." Xu Qingzhu said: "From the current situation, this is the most convenient and easily acceptable method, so don't be restrained. Just follow the rules."

Liang Shi: "..."

She increasingly felt that Xu Qingzhu wasn't talking to "Liang Shi," but rather to a strange woman.

She had completely placed her in the position of a stranger, yet had developed a little bit of trust.

Just as she was thinking, Xu Qingzhu, lying there, suddenly said: "I think I had a dream yesterday."

Liang Shi instinctively responded: "What?"

"I dreamed about you." Xu Qingzhu said.

Liang Shi: "...?"

"I dreamed you were lying there." Xu Qingzhu pointed to one side of the bed, "holding your phone watching a movie."

Liang Shi: "Ah?"

That wasn't a dream.

"But it seemed to be an adult film." Xu Qingzhu said with a shrug, "Anyway, it was a strange dream."

Liang Shi couldn't help but say: "That wasn't a dream."

Xu Qingzhu frowned, her tone slightly surprised: "Hm? So you really were watching an adult film?"

Liang Shi: "...No, it was just a regular movie."

Xu Qingzhu smiled.

Obviously didn't believe her.

Just as Liang Shi was about to explain, Xu Qingzhu looked at her, her eyes curving into crescents, and advised in that aloof voice: "Movies are good, but don't watch too many, okay?"

Liang Shi: "?"

Xu Qingzhu continued: "Or watch them when you're alone, alright?"

Liang Shi: "..."

She began to regret - why didn't she record Xu Qingzhu's drunken behavior yesterday?

That way she could play it on loop for Xu Qingzhu before bedtime.

If they were going to die of embarrassment, they should die together.